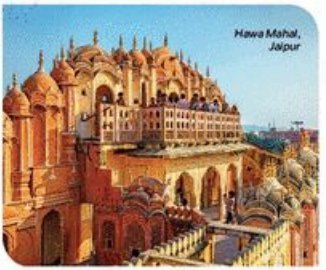
JAIPUR

Having struck a fine balance between modernity and heritage, Jaipur is now a template for great cities to follow. The Pink City's several forts speak of a fairy-tale grandeur. The history of the Amer Fort, for instance, is as fascinating as its byzantine passages. Whether it's the City Palace in the centre of the city or the Jal Palace in the middle of Man Sagar Lake, the royal past of Jaipur is still accessible today.



Hawa Mahal, Jaipur



Bhimtal's centrepiece, the pristine lake

BHIMTAL

Legend has it that finding Draupadi thirsty once, Bhima struck the ground with his mace. The water that gushed out gave the area a lake and the town, Bhimtal, its name. Once the best route between the Kumaon mountains and the Indian plains, the scenic Bhimtal, located at an altitude of 4,494 ft, is the perfect getaway for nature lovers and trekkers, but, also, for artists and writers looking for quiet.



Party time at Mehrangarh Fort

JODHPUR

Built in 1459 by Rao Jodha, Jodhpur's Mehrangarh Fort was the site of many a battle, and the museum here recounts several Rajput tales of valour. The rulers of Jodhpur, however, were as attracted to opulence as they were to bravery. Built in the 1920s, Umaid Bhavan Palace is proof of their regal taste.

ALWAR

Barely a three-hour drive from Delhi, the erstwhile princely state of Alwar lies nestled in the heart of the Aravallis. The Bala Qila or Alwar Fort sits majestically on a hill 300 m above the city, while the City Palace or Vinay Vilas Mahal houses extraordinary Rajput and Mughal art. The Nikumbha Mahal Palace and the Tomb of Fateh Jung are also feats of Rajput architecture that deserve a place on your itinerary.